

# TOWARDS FREEDOM

The exorbitant costs incurred during World War II (1939–45) brought the Empire to its knees and its hegemony started to wane. Great Britain no longer possessed the political will or the economic might to hold on to India – the jewel in its crown. Despite a growing realization that it was the beginning of the end for British rule in India, the railways showed no signs of slowing down. Passenger traffic continued to grow as did work on expanding the railway network, which steadily fuelled India's march to freedom.



▲ **Engineers of the 136 Indian Railway Maintenance Company** laying down rails in Bologna a week before the German surrender in Italy in April 1945.